investment. A good amount of Plan funds were also allocated for agriculture, especially during the First Plan.

In the first phase, from 1947–1964, India relied on three strategic interventions to realize the goal of 100 million tonnes foodgrain production: bring in additional area under cultivation; increase irrigation; and expand availability of fertilizers and improved seeds. The first two strategic interventions were the primary focus of attention and the third intervention was more lip service.

The area expansion strategy did succeed. Almost the entire area expansion India has witnessed in the past seventy-three years took place in the 1950s and 1960s. The net area sown at the end of the Third Plan in 1966 reached 140 million hectares. Even today, the net sown area in India is about the same.

Over two-thirds of Plan outlays on agriculture during this period went towards irrigation investments. However, dam and surface irrigation proved to be a very slow moving investment. There were too many issues in building dams: acquisition of land, relocating and rehabilitating people, tough and unsuitable terrain and difficulty in taking plant and machinery to such interior and mountainous regions. Not surprisingly, despite substantial irrigation outlays, the irrigated area increased only at a snail's pace of an average 0.4 million hectares per year. The net irrigated area increased from 21 million hectares in 1950–51 to only 27 million hectares in 1966–67.

India's use of fertilizer and new seeds was pathetically low at the time of Independence. Indian farmers used a total of 66,000 tonnes of fertilizer nutrients in 1950–51. Fertilizer consumption rose to 7,85,000 tonnes in 1965–66, which was still minuscule in the context of the needs of Indian agriculture. In terms of seeds, the age of high-yielding seeds had barely taken birth by the time the Third Plan ended.

Only marginal gains were made in the agriculture and food situation from 1947 to 1964, which were also more than neutralized by the increase